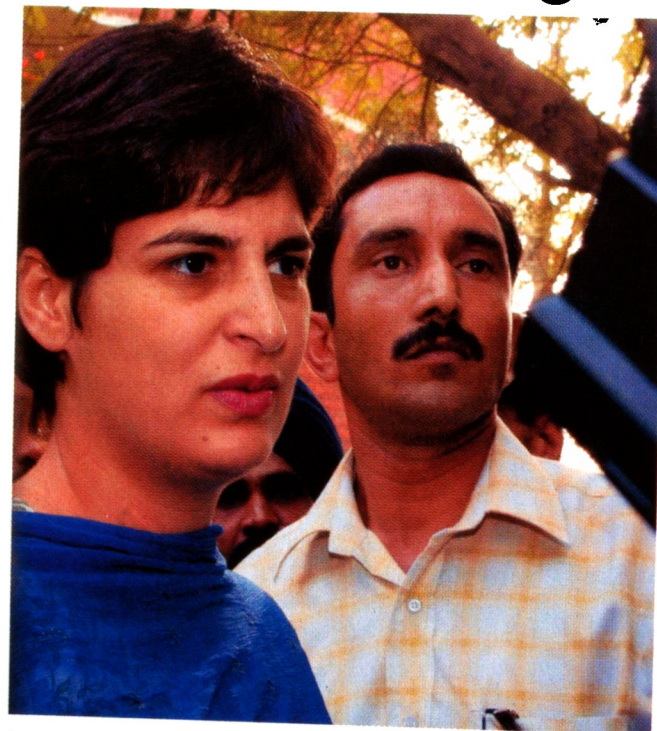


Forgive But Not Forget

DELHI Conventional logic would suggest that if Priyanka Gandhi-Vadra crossed paths with Nalini Sriharan, one of the conspirators in Rajiv Gandhi's assassination, both would choose to look the other way. It came as a surprise then that Priyanka visited the Vellore Jail on March 19 to meet her father's killer. It was a "very personal visit and completely on my own initiative", she later clarified. Anything that a Gandhi-Nehru does automatically becomes public fodder. Some have dismissed her meeting with Sriharan as yet another gimmick from the dynasty while others sympathise with a daughter still trying to come to terms with her father's brutal death.

The questions that Priyanka asked Sriharan were those that anyone would want answered. "My father was a good person. Why did you have



MAKING PEACE WITH HERSELF: Priyanka Gandhi

to kill him?" she asked. "It was my own way of coming to peace with the violence and loss that I have experienced," Priyanka later said.

Adds her brother and Congress General Secretary Rahul Gandhi, "We don't carry anger, we don't carry hatred."

But the siblings' state-

ments do not shed light on the timing of the visit, coming as it did nearly 17 years after Rajiv's death. Priyanka has stayed in the background, with an occasional visits to the Gandhi dynasty stronghold Amethi or accompanying her brother and mother to rallies. Incidentally, it was at Sonia's intervention that Sriharan's death sentence was commuted to life imprisonment. Sonia had said that she did not want Sriharan's daughter to be orphaned.

Congressmen claim that Priyanka's visit was another gesture arising from the same school of thought. Once whilst visiting a temple in Amethi, Priyanka was asked if she had prayed for a poll win for her brother. Pat had come the answer: "I don't mix religion with politics." Likewise, this visit too, she claims, was personal, not politically motivated.

by Priya Sahgal

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

Muslim League MP Abdul Wahab's threat to seek action against the Air-India pilot who offloaded him from a flight for arriving late may remain just a threat as the Pilots' Guild is headed by Vikram Yadav, son-in-law of Lalu Prasad Yadav.

VOICES



"We can't stop migrants. But they can't misuse Mumbai's infrastructure, which is already heavily burdened and is meant for taxpayers."

Vilasrao Deshmukh, Maharashtra chief minister

"Price rise is the most crucial issue and it will be like a large albatross around the UPA's neck in the coming election. We are telling them that they will be in trouble."

Sitaram Yechury, CPI(M) Politburo member

"Indians don't need a visa to live and work with dignity in any part of the country. North Indians should refrain from making provocative statements if they face criticism."

Shatrughan Singh, BJP leader and actor

"The world knows that the Dalai Lama is not seeking independence nor separation from China. Our struggle is with a few in the leadership, not with the Chinese people."

Dalai Lama, Tibetan spiritual leader

"VIPs, ministers, politicians or people from the entertainment industry have little right to carry the (Beijing Olympics) torch. It belongs to sportspersons."

M.S. Gill, sports minister

